The frontier between Ladakh and Tibet can be traced back to the tenth century when a Tibetan prince, Skyid-Ida-Ngeemagon, conferred the Meryal (Ladakh) fief to his eldest son. In 1681 and 1683, the Tibetans, aided by Mongols, invaded Ladakh. In 1684, a peace treaty between the two sides was concluded that read: 'The boundaries fixed in the beginning, when Skyid-Ida-Ngeemagon gave a kingdom to each of his three sons, should still be maintained.'

The peace treaty was scrupulously honoured by both sides for a century and a half. The year 1821 marked the beginning of the Sikh/Dogra expansion northwards when Gulab Singh's mercurial rise under Maharaja Ranjit Singh would make the Dogras under General Zorawar Singh important players in Kashmir and Ladakh. In 1835, Zorawar led his men across the Great Himalayan Range through Umasi-la and arrived at Padam. From here he moved westwards, capturing the Suru River Valley and the small town of Kargil. In the next four years, he had the entire region of Ladakh and Baltistan under his control.

In 1841, Zorawar Singh once again crossed into Ladakh. His 5,000-strong army, supplemented by another 2,000 men from Kishtwar, Ladakh and Baltistan, advanced eastwards along the Indus River and brushed aside all Tibetan opposition at Rudok and Tashigang. By September the Dogras had set up base at Taklakot near the Manasarovar Lake where they hastily constructed a small fort. This location was twenty-four kilometres from the borders of Nepal and Kumaon.

Zorawar Singh's exploits changed the map of northern India and threatened to completely undo the carefully cultivated relationship between Lhasa and the British. While the Tibetans had been at the receiving end militarily, the British had been viewing Zorawar Singh's advance with alarm; from their point of view a direct link between Lahore (the Sikhs) and Nepal (the Gorkhas) was most undesirable, and they had been putting relentless pressure on the Lahore Durbar to press Gulab Singh to recall Zorawar Singh and vacate the Tibetan territory occupied by him.

However, Zorawar Singh had already achieved all that he could in the region. The intense cold and lack of supplies had immobilized his army, and to make matters worse, the Tibetans, aware of the threat to Lhasa, had put together a large force to neutralize the Dogras. Boldly seeking to engage the Tibetans rather than sit back and wait for them to attack him, the Dogras were overcome at Toyu (at over 16,000 feet) on 11-12 December, 1841.